

IMPACT.

CONVERSION

FREE PLAYBOOK · D2C ECOMMERCE

The 7 Conversion Killers of D2C Ecommerce Stores

The patterns we see on almost every audit, the damage each one causes, and the fastest way to fix it. Plain English, no fluff.

Symptoms to spot

Fast fixes

Score yourself at the end

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How to use this playbook

Twenty minutes with this document should leave you with two or three fixes you can ship this month, and a score that tells you where your funnel leaks worst.

1

Skim all seven killers and mark where you nod

Each killer opens with the symptoms. If you recognise more than one symptom, you probably have the problem.

2

Ship the fast fixes you can do this week

Every killer ends with fixes ordered roughly by effort. Start with the ones that need a copy change, not a rebuild.

3

Score yourself at the end

Seven killers, zero to two points each. The score tells you whether you are leaking everywhere or just need to tighten one stage.

WHO THIS IS FOR

D2C ecommerce brands doing **1,000+ orders a month or \$1M+ a year in online revenue**. That is the volume where A/B testing reads become reliable. If you are under that, the fixes still apply, but skip the testing advice and use the low-traffic notes instead: ship the change, watch revenue per visitor for a few weeks, and favour bigger swings over small tweaks.

One rule before everything else: every killer in this document is found by research, not by opinion. When you are unsure whether a killer applies to you, ask your buyers. A one-question post-purchase survey ("What almost stopped you from buying today?") finds more leaks than any checklist, including this one.

01 The hero that talks about you instead of them

Most homepage heroes name the product, the brand, and the year founded, and never name the problem the buyer is trying to solve. The visitor gives you about five seconds before they decide whether to scroll, and a hero about you wastes all five of them.

HOW TO SPOT IT

The 5-second test fails

Show your homepage to someone outside the company for five seconds. If they cannot say who it is for and what they get, you have this killer.

The logo-swap test fails

Put a competitor's logo on your hero. If the page still reads fine, your headline is generic enough to belong to anyone.

Thin scroll, fast exits

Scroll maps show visitors stalling at the fold. Cold traffic bounces while returning visitors convert fine, because they already know what you do.

THE FIX

1

Lead with the outcome, not the brand

One sentence that names who the product is for and the result they get. Pull the exact words from your reviews and post-purchase surveys. Your customers have already written your best headline.

2

Put your top two objections in the subhead

Whatever almost stops people from buying (price, fit, durability, shipping time) gets answered directly under the headline, not buried in an FAQ.

3

Anchor proof at the fold

One review, one stat, or one recognisable logo within the first screen. A claim without proof next to it is just a slogan.

02 Price anchoring that works against you

The first price a buyer sees sets the anchor for every cart that follows. Most D2C sites lead with their cheapest SKU, on the homepage, in collections, and in ads, which quietly caps average order value across the entire range.

HOW TO SPOT IT

AOV hugs your entry price

Average order value sits close to your cheapest product, and items per order hovers near one.

Collections sort cheap-first

Your default collection sort, your featured products, and your best-sellers row all open on the lowest-priced items.

Premium SKUs are invisible

Your highest-margin products get a fraction of the product-page traffic, and almost none of it from internal navigation.

THE FIX

1

Lead with the product you want to sell

Put your hero SKU or your bundle first in collections and on the homepage. Let the cheap option be the downgrade people choose, not the default they start from.

2

Show the range on the product page

A good-better-best presentation on the PDP lets the buyer anchor on the middle or top option. Single-option pages anchor on whatever the ad promised, which is usually the discount.

3

Test the anchor, not just the price

Before discounting anything, test the order in which prices appear. Re-ordering is free. Discounting never is.

Low-traffic note: price and anchoring changes move real money in both directions. If you cannot A/B test, change one thing at a time and watch revenue per visitor weekly, not conversion rate alone.

03 PDPs that answer questions nobody is asking

When the FAQ block covers returns and shipping but says nothing about whether the product fits the buyer's specific situation, you are usually one paragraph of copy away from the sale. The product page is where the buying decision actually happens, and most of them are written from the spec sheet instead of from the customer's questions.

HOW TO SPOT IT

Support asks the same questions

Your support inbox and chat keep answering the same three pre-sale questions. Those questions are missing from the PDP.

Reviews get read, copy does not

Heatmaps show buyers skipping your description and digging through reviews. They are hunting for the answer your copy did not give.

High traffic, weak add-to-cart

The PDP gets plenty of visits and decent time on page, but add-to-cart stays flat. People are interested and unconvinced.

THE FIX

1

Mine your reviews and tickets for the real questions

Pull the last 100 reviews and 50 support conversations. List every question and hesitation. The five most common ones become PDP copy, placed above the fold, not in a collapsed FAQ.

2

Write for the use case, not the spec

"300g" is a spec. "Light enough to forget it is in your pack" is an answer. Every spec on the page should be translated into what it means for the buyer.

3

Show the product in use

Real in-use imagery beats studio renders for first-time buyers. They are trying to picture themselves using it. Help them.

04 Free shipping thresholds that cost you margin

A free-shipping threshold that looks like a conversion win can quietly be a profit loser once fulfilment cost is counted. Most thresholds get set once, by gut feel, and never get modelled against real basket data again.

HOW TO SPOT IT

The threshold is a round number

If your threshold is \$50 or \$100 because it sounded right, it has never been modelled. Real basket data almost never lands on a round number.

Orders cluster just over it

A spike of orders sitting barely above the threshold means buyers are padding carts with low-margin filler to qualify, and you are paying to ship it.

Shipping appears late

If the buyer first learns the shipping cost inside checkout, you get the worst of both: full fulfilment cost on some orders and abandonment on the rest.

THE FIX

1

Model the threshold on your own basket data

Take your real order distribution and compute what each candidate threshold does to margin after fulfilment, not just to conversion. The right threshold sits just above a natural cluster in your order values, where a small nudge moves the most orders up.

2

Make the threshold work for AOV

A progress bar in the cart ("\$12 away from free shipping") paired with a sensible suggested add-on turns the threshold from a cost into an AOV lever.

3

State shipping early

Whatever your policy is, surface it on the PDP and in the cart. Surprise shipping cost at checkout is one of the most reliable abandonment triggers in ecommerce.

Do the maths first: we built a free calculator that models exactly this from your order data: impactconversion.com/tools/shipping-calculator

05 The checkout that re-introduces doubt

You spend the whole site building trust, then the checkout asks for a coupon code the buyer does not have, surfaces a strange shipping fee, and demands an account before payment. Every one of those moments hands the buyer a reason to leave at the exact point they had decided to stay.

HOW TO SPOT IT

Checkout abandonment is the leak

Funnel data shows healthy add-to-cart and cart-to-checkout, then a cliff between checkout start and purchase.

The coupon field leaks

Session recordings show buyers leaving checkout to hunt for discount codes. Some come back. Many do not.

Rage clicks and form restarts

Recordings show repeated taps on fields, validation errors on mobile, and buyers re-typing details the form lost.

THE FIX

1 Guest checkout, always

Never force account creation before payment. Create the account silently after the order if you need it.

2 Tame the coupon field

Collapse it behind a small link, and if you run a public welcome offer, auto-apply it. The field should never advertise that other people are paying less.

3 Audit the form like a buyer on a phone

Ten or fewer visible fields, autofill enabled, the right mobile keyboards, inline validation, and express payment options (Apple Pay, Google Pay, PayPal) above the manual form.

4 Keep trust visible at the point of payment

Recognisable payment marks, the guarantee, and the returns policy belong within sight of the pay button. Doubt peaks right before commitment.

06 Upsells that feel like upsells

Bundles and cross-sells work when they extend the job the buyer hired the product to do. They stall when they look like the store is just trying to add another line to the order. The difference is relevance, timing, and how the offer is framed.

HOW TO SPOT IT

Attach rates in the low single digits

Your cart cross-sell or order bump gets shown to everyone and taken by almost no one. Shown is not the same as relevant.

One recommendation for every basket

The same three products get recommended no matter what is in the cart, because the app shipped with defaults and nobody changed them.

Buyers call it pushy

Survey responses or support tickets describe the extras as confusing or pushy. Mismatched offers cost trust as well as the sale.

THE FIX

1 Match the offer to the basket

The cross-sell should complete the job: the case for the camera, the refill for the bottle, the second unit for the household. Rule-based beats algorithm-default at most D2C catalogue sizes.

2 Frame it as completing the kit

"Complete the set" outperforms "You may also like" because it gives a reason. Price the add-on meaningfully below the main item so the decision feels small.

3 Test which logic fires, not whether to upsell

The question is never upsell or no upsell. It is which offer, at which moment, to which basket. Treat each as a separate test.

07 Post-purchase pages that sell nothing

The thank-you page holds the highest-intent traffic on your entire site. The buyer just paid. Trust and momentum will never be higher. Most brands use that moment to say thanks and send a receipt, leaving a large pile of margin sitting on the floor.

HOW TO SPOT IT

The thank-you page is a receipt

Order number, delivery estimate, nothing else. No offer, no referral ask, no reason to come back.

Repeat rate stalls

Your 90-day repurchase rate sits under ten percent and nothing in the post-purchase flow is working to change it.

Items per order is stuck at one

Nobody is ever shown a sensible second offer at the moment they are most likely to take it.

THE FIX

1

One-click post-purchase offer

A single yes-or-no offer straight after payment, no re-entering card details. One client's post-purchase offer hit a 26 percent take rate and lifted AOV 15 percent. This surface is routinely the easiest win in the whole funnel.

2

Make the first week earn the second order

A short post-purchase email sequence that helps the buyer get value from what they bought converts better than a discount blast ever will. Usage drives repurchase.

3

Ask for the review at the win moment

Trigger the review and referral ask when the product lands and gets used, not three minutes after checkout. Timing is most of the response rate.

SCORE YOURSELF

Where does your store stand?

Zero, one, or two points per killer. 0 = big problem, no system in place. 1 = some effort, inconsistent. 2 = handled: documented, measured, consistent.

01 · Hero names the buyer's problem

☐ 0 ☐ 1 ☐ 2

02 · Price anchoring works for you

☐ 0 ☐ 1 ☐ 2

03 · PDP answers the real questions

☐ 0 ☐ 1 ☐ 2

04 · Shipping threshold modelled on data

☐ 0 ☐ 1 ☐ 2

05 · Checkout free of doubt and friction

☐ 0 ☐ 1 ☐ 2

06 · Upsells extend the job, attach well

☐ 0 ☐ 1 ☐ 2

07 · Post-purchase actively sells

☐ 0 ☐ 1 ☐ 2

READ YOUR TOTAL (OUT OF 14)

0 to 6

You are leaking revenue at almost every stage. The good news: the first few fixes will be the cheapest revenue you ever add.

7 to 10

The foundations are there. A focused 30-day push on your two weakest killers usually pays for itself.

11 to 14

You are close. The gains now come from testing discipline and speed, not from obvious fixes.

The honest caveat: a checklist finds the common leaks. It cannot find yours specifically. That takes research on your buyers and proper A/B tests on your traffic, which is exactly what we do all day.

NEXT STEP, IF YOU WANT ONE

Want us to find your leaks for you?

Book a free 15-minute intro call. We will look at your funnel together and tell you straight whether a CRO program is worth running on your traffic. No pitch deck, no sales script.

[Book a 15-min intro call →](#)

The guarantee on every 90-day sprint: you see a revenue uplift, or we refund the final 50% of the sprint fee. The full terms are at impactconversion.com/guarantee.

Prefer email? jono@impactconversion.com. If you send your score from the previous page, you will get a straight answer on where to focus first.